

openhouse

art & design · ages 8-12

the artiverse book

the art we make – and why



a teacher's companion to every artwork · 11 units

why these artworks – in this order

Every artwork here is a **real piece by a working artist**, chosen because it teaches a specific **skill** through a technique a child can genuinely do. The units run **easiest → hardest**, each carries a **medium symbol**, and together they cover the five spiral skills.

 oil pastel
  watercolour
  acrylic
  mixed media
  pencil

1	 donut acrylic	S&F	C&P	● ● ● ● ●	
2	 colour grid study watercolour	C&P	B&C	● ● ● ● ●	
3	 blue lotus watercolour	C&P	L&T	● ● ● ● ●	
4	 pear · glazing watercolour	C&P	S&F	● ● ● ● ●	
5	 jellyfish watercolour	C&P	L&T	● ● ● ● ●	
6	 octopus watercolour	S&F	C&P	● ● ● ● ●	
7	 klee portrait mixed media	B&C	S&F	I&C	● ● ● ● ●
8	 self-portrait watercolour	C&P	I&C	B&C	● ● ● ● ●
9	 van gogh landscape oil pastels	C&P	L&T	● ● ● ● ●	
10	 3d cube pencil	S&F	C&P	● ● ● ● ●	
11	 dragonfly at night acrylic on black paper	C&P	B&C	● ● ● ● ●	

skills across the book: line & texture · shape & form · colour & painting · balance & composition · imagination & collaboration – revisited at rising difficulty (the spiral).

donut 🍩

acrylic

the objective

Lay clean, flat areas of colour with crisp edges – no blending.

skills it builds

shape & form

colour & painting

the technique

Flat fill, colour blocking – fill each area with even, solid colour up to a clean edge, one at a time.

1. Sketch the donut shapes.
2. Fill each area with flat, even colour.
3. Add sprinkles and highlights last.

why it's good for children

Colour blocking builds control and a **designer's eye** – clean edges and confident flat colour are the foundation of graphic art, and the playful subject keeps a technical skill fun.

how to encourage them

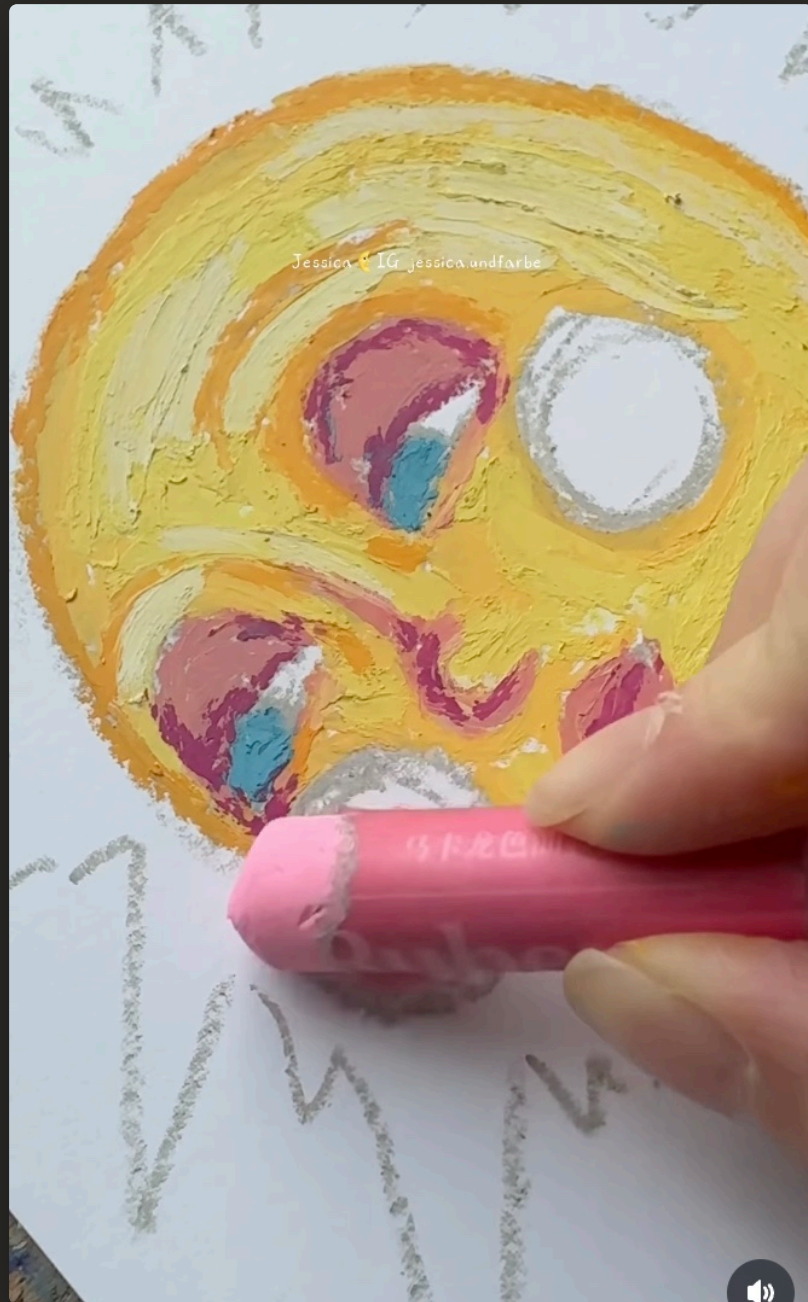
"Even colour, clean edge – take your time."

materials

acrylic · a brush · paper

where it sits in the spiral

the disciplined starting point – precision that the tonal units build on.



what we make – a bold, appetising donut

artwork shown as inspiration, with thanks to the artist

► artist's instagram reel – credit to be added

topic options: a sprinkled donut · a box of donuts · a bitten donut

colour grid study 💧

watercolour

the objective

Mix and place colours deliberately in a grid, exploring how they relate side by side.

skills it builds

colour & painting

balance & composition

the technique

Colour theory – mix a clean colour for each square and place warm and cool families thoughtfully.

1. Draw a simple grid.
2. Mix and fill each square with one clean colour.
3. Arrange warm and cool so the grid feels balanced.

why it's good for children

A grid makes **colour itself** the subject – children practise mixing and see how colours change beside each other, the foundation of every painting that follows.

how to encourage them

"Which colours feel warm? which feel cool? put them where they belong."

materials

watercolours · a palette · paper

where it sits in the spiral

pure colour practice underpinning the painting units.



what we make – a grid of mixed colours

artwork shown as inspiration, with thanks to the artist

► artist's instagram reel – credit to be added

topic options: a warm-cool grid · a rainbow grid · a tone grid

blue lotus

watercolour

the objective

Build a flower from clean transparent washes, petal by petal, with restraint.

skills it builds

colour & painting

line & texture

the technique

Light washes, layering – lay a clean wash for each petal, letting the white paper show, and deepen tone where petals overlap.

1. Mix watery, transparent blue.
2. Paint each petal as one clean wash.
3. Deepen the tone where petals meet.

why it's good for children

Watercolour rewards **restraint** – leaving the white of the paper and not overworking a wash is a skill in itself. Building petal by petal teaches patience and control.

how to encourage them

"Less is more – let the water do the work."

materials

watercolours · a round brush · watercolour paper

where it sits in the spiral

clean layered washes – the ground for glazing next.



what we make – a blue lotus in clean washes

artwork shown as inspiration, with thanks to the artist

► artist's instagram reel – credit to be added

topic options: a lotus · a water lily · a single bloom

pear · glazing 💧

watercolour

the objective

Layer transparent washes (glazing) to build a rounded, glowing form.

skills it builds

colour & painting

shape & form

the technique

Glazing – let each wash dry, then add another transparent layer on top to deepen colour and build roundness.

1. Lay a pale first wash for the whole pear.
2. When dry, glaze a deeper layer on the shadow side.
3. Keep glazing until the pear looks round and glowing.

why it's good for children

Glazing is a genuinely advanced idea – children learn that **transparent layers** build form and light without muddying the colour. It grows patience and an eye for tone.

how to encourage them

“Wait for it to dry, then add the next glaze.” Discourage rushing.

materials

watercolours · a brush · watercolour paper · a real pear

where it sits in the spiral

layering becomes form – tone deepens through the book.

wash of this pear



what we make – a glowing pear

artwork shown as inspiration, with thanks to the artist

► artist's instagram reel – credit to be added

topic options: a single pear · a pair of pears · a pear and its shadow

jellyfish 💧

watercolour

the objective

Use wet-into-wet washes to make a soft, translucent, moving form.

skills it builds

colour & painting

line & texture

the technique

Wet-into-wet – wet the paper, drop in colour and let it bloom softly; pull long trailing tentacles with a fine brush.

1. Wet the bell area and drop in soft colour.
2. Let the colours bloom and blend on their own.
3. Pull long, wavy tentacles while damp.

why it's good for children

Wet-into-wet is watercolour at its most magical and least controllable – children learn to **let go** and work with the water, capturing movement and translucency.

how to encourage them

"Let the water carry the colour – don't fight it."

materials

watercolours · a soft brush · watercolour paper

where it sits in the spiral

the loosest, most atmospheric watercolour – movement and light together.



what we make – a drifting jellyfish

artwork shown as inspiration, with thanks to the artist

► artist's instagram reel – credit to be added

topic options: a single jellyfish · a bloom of jellyfish · a deep-sea drift

octopus

watercolour

the objective

Capture a soft, moving creature with flowing washes and curling line.

skills it builds

shape & form

colour & painting

the technique

Form & movement – build the body with a wash, then pull curling arms with a loaded brush, varying the pressure.

1. Paint the soft, rounded body.
2. Pull eight curling arms with a flowing brush.
3. Add suckers and pattern once dry.

why it's good for children

An octopus asks for both **soft form and lively line** – children observe a moving creature and translate it into confident, curling marks.

how to encourage them

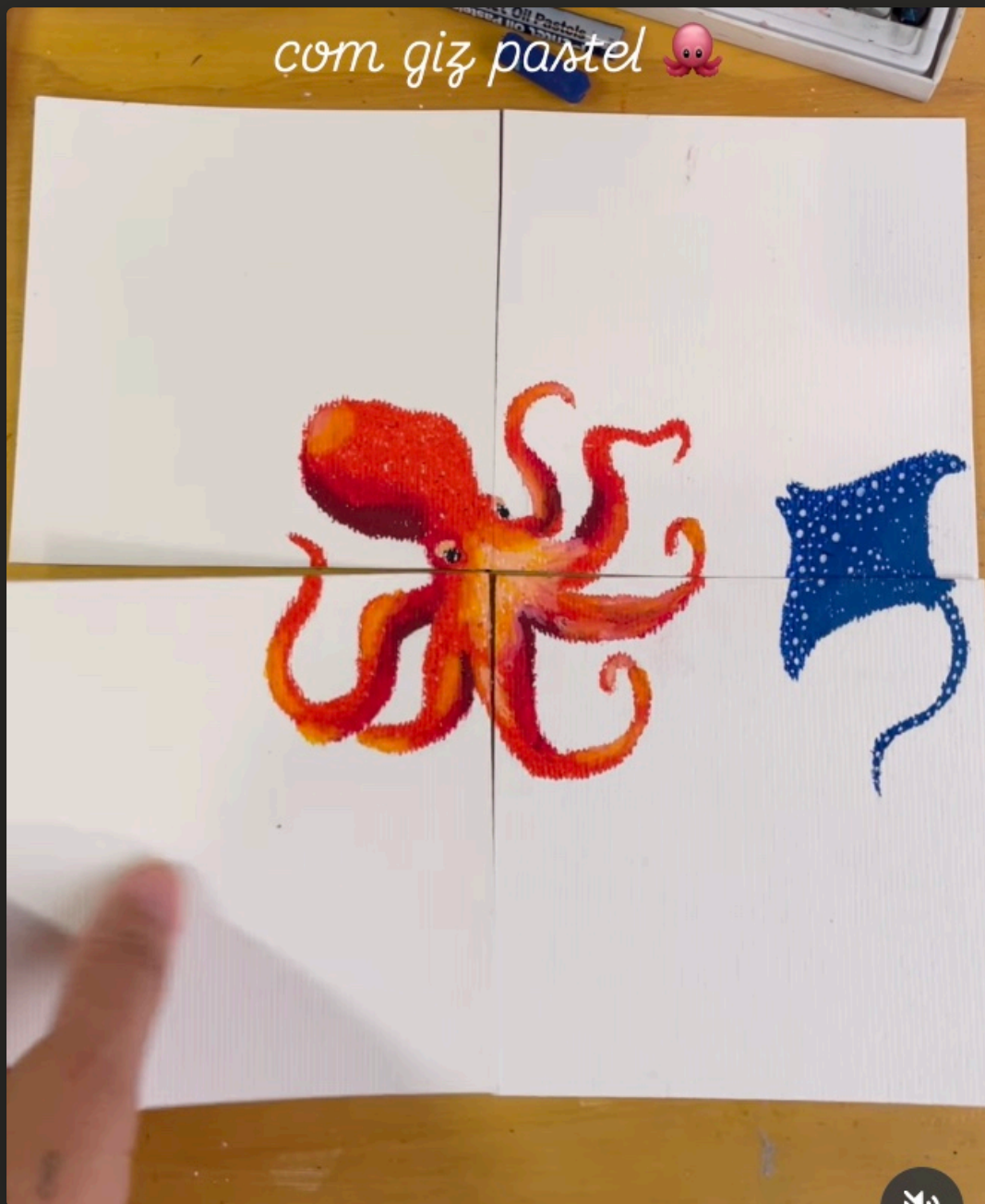
Show a real octopus clip. *"Make the arms curl and move."*

materials

watercolours · a round brush · paper

where it sits in the spiral

washes plus expressive line – a step toward the mark-driven units.



what we make – a curling octopus

artwork shown as inspiration, with thanks to the artist

► artist's instagram reel – credit to be added

topic options: an octopus · a squid · a sea creature in motion

klee portrait

mixed media

the objective

Build a portrait from geometric shapes and warm colour (Paul Klee's 'Senecio').

skills it builds

balance & composition

shape & form

imagination & collaboration

the technique

Geometric portrait – divide a face into circles, triangles and rectangles, then fill with warm, balanced colour.

1. Draw a round face and divide it into shapes.
2. Colour each shape with warm, balanced colour.
3. Keep the eyes and mouth simple and geometric.

why it's good for children

Building a face from **shapes, not likeness** makes portraits achievable and joyful, and studying Klee links the child's work to art history. Balancing colour across the face is real composition.

how to encourage them

Show Klee's *Senecio*. *"Which shape is the nose? the eyes?"*

materials

oil pastel / paint · paper

where it sits in the spiral

composition meets art history; balance deepens here.



what we make – a face built from shapes

artwork shown as inspiration, with thanks to the artist

► artist's instagram reel – credit to be added

topic options: a face of shapes · a portrait in warm colour · a Senecio of my own

self-portrait

watercolour

the objective

Paint a self-portrait using bold, non-literal colour to express identity and mood.

skills it builds

colour & painting

imagination & collaboration

balance & composition

the technique

Expressive colour – paint the face in confident, unexpected colours that capture a feeling rather than exact likeness.

1. Sketch the face large and simple.
2. Paint it in bold, expressive colour.
3. Add strong marks for hair and features.

why it's good for children

A self-portrait is deeply **personal**, and using bold colour frees children from needing an exact likeness – they express identity and mood, growing confidence and self-expression.

how to encourage them

"What colour is your mood today? paint yourself in it." Celebrate boldness.

materials

watercolours · a brush · paper

where it sits in the spiral

colour becomes expression and identity.



what we make – an expressive self-portrait

artwork shown as inspiration, with thanks to the artist

► artist's instagram reel – credit to be added

topic options: me in bold colour · my face, my mood · a fearless portrait

van gogh landscape

oil pastels

the objective

Use bold directional marks to fill a landscape with movement and mood (Van Gogh).

skills it builds

colour & painting

line & texture

the technique

Expressive marks – layer oil pastel in swirling, directional strokes so the whole scene seems to move.

1. Lay directional strokes for sky, field and trees.
2. Layer colours in the same flowing direction.
3. Blend a little to make the marks move.

why it's good for children

Van Gogh's method shows children that **marks carry emotion** – the direction of a stroke creates movement and feeling. It links technique to expression, a sophisticated idea.

how to encourage them

Show a Van Gogh landscape. *"Make the whole picture move."*

materials

oil pastels · paper

where it sits in the spiral

mark-making becomes expressive across a whole scene.



what we make – a landscape full of movement

artwork shown as inspiration, with thanks to the artist

► artist's instagram reel – credit to be added

topic options: cypresses · a wheatfield · a swirling sky

3d cube

pencil

the objective

Understand how one light source creates volume through graduated tone.

skills it builds

shape & form

colour & painting

the technique

Light, shadow, 3D form – pick a light direction, then shade each face lighter or darker so the shape looks solid.

1. Draw the cube's three visible faces.
2. Choose where the light comes from.
3. Shade each face lighter or darker to match.

why it's good for children

A genuine leap into **how we see form** – a flat shape becomes a solid object through tone alone. It's the foundation of realistic drawing and a real 'aha'.

how to encourage them

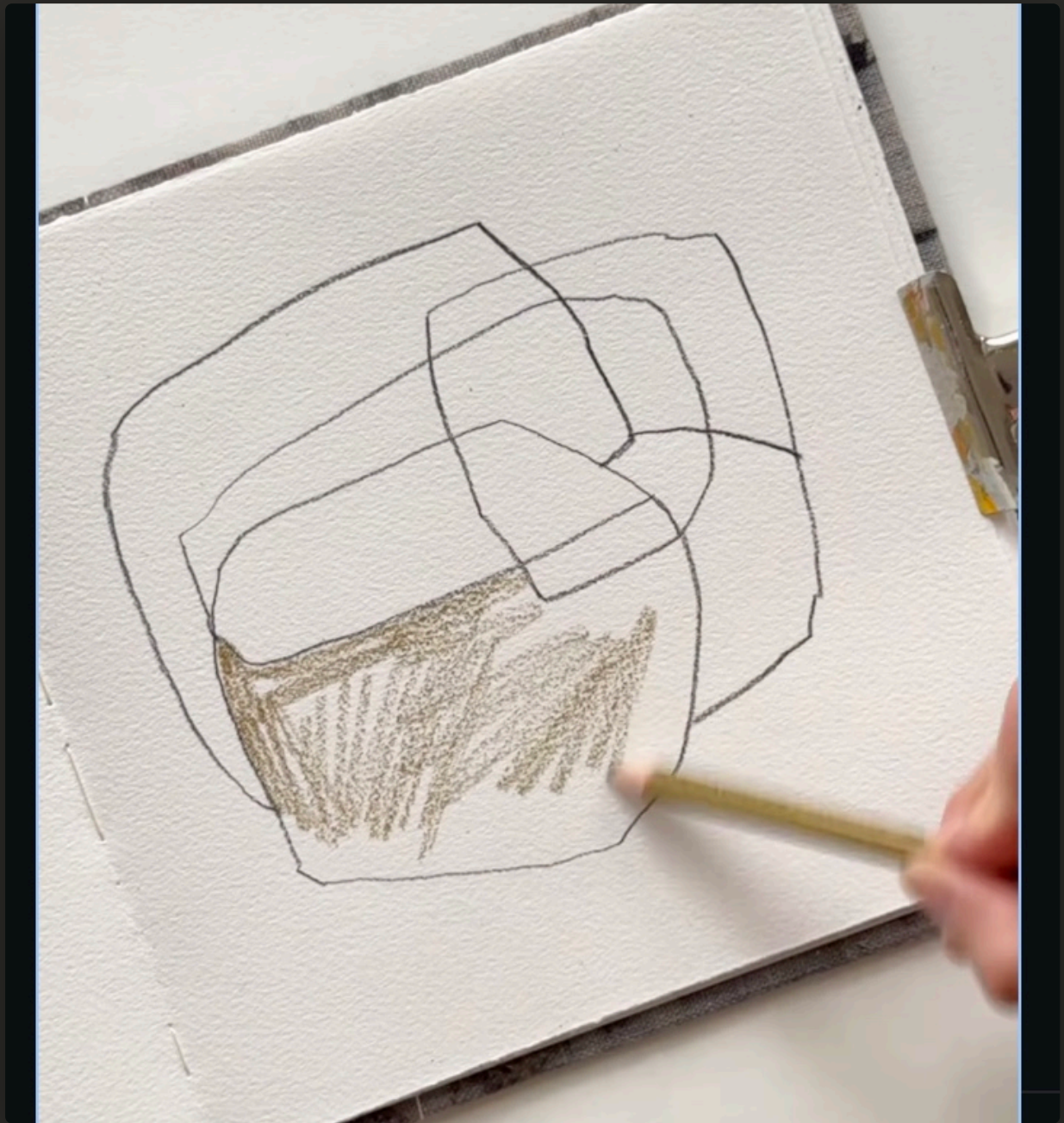
Shine a light on a real box. *"Which face is lightest? darkest?"*

materials

graphite pencil · paper · a box + a lamp

where it sits in the spiral

tone becomes form – the structure beneath all representational art.



what we make – a solid 3d form

artwork shown as inspiration, with thanks to the artist

► artist's instagram reel – credit to be added

topic options: a cube · stacked blocks · a row of 3D shapes

dragonfly at night 🎨

acrylic on black paper

the objective

Work on a dark ground, building from dark to light to make things glow.

skills it builds

colour & painting

balance & composition

the technique

Painting with light – on black paper, add light and bright colours so the creature appears to glow against the dark.

1. Start on black paper – plan where the light is.
2. Build glows softly with white and bright colour.
3. Add the brightest highlights last, sparingly.

why it's good for children

Reversing the usual approach – **light on dark** – is the hardest and most magical idea in the book. It asks children to think about **light itself**, plan an atmosphere, and hold back. A glowing result feels like magic they made.

how to encourage them

"The dark makes the light glow – use it sparingly."

materials

acrylic · black paper · a fine brush

where it sits in the spiral

the book's peak – colour, composition and atmosphere on the hardest ground.



what we make – a glowing night creature

artwork shown as inspiration, with thanks to the artist

► artist's instagram reel – credit to be added

topic options: a dragonfly · fireflies in a jar · a glowing pond